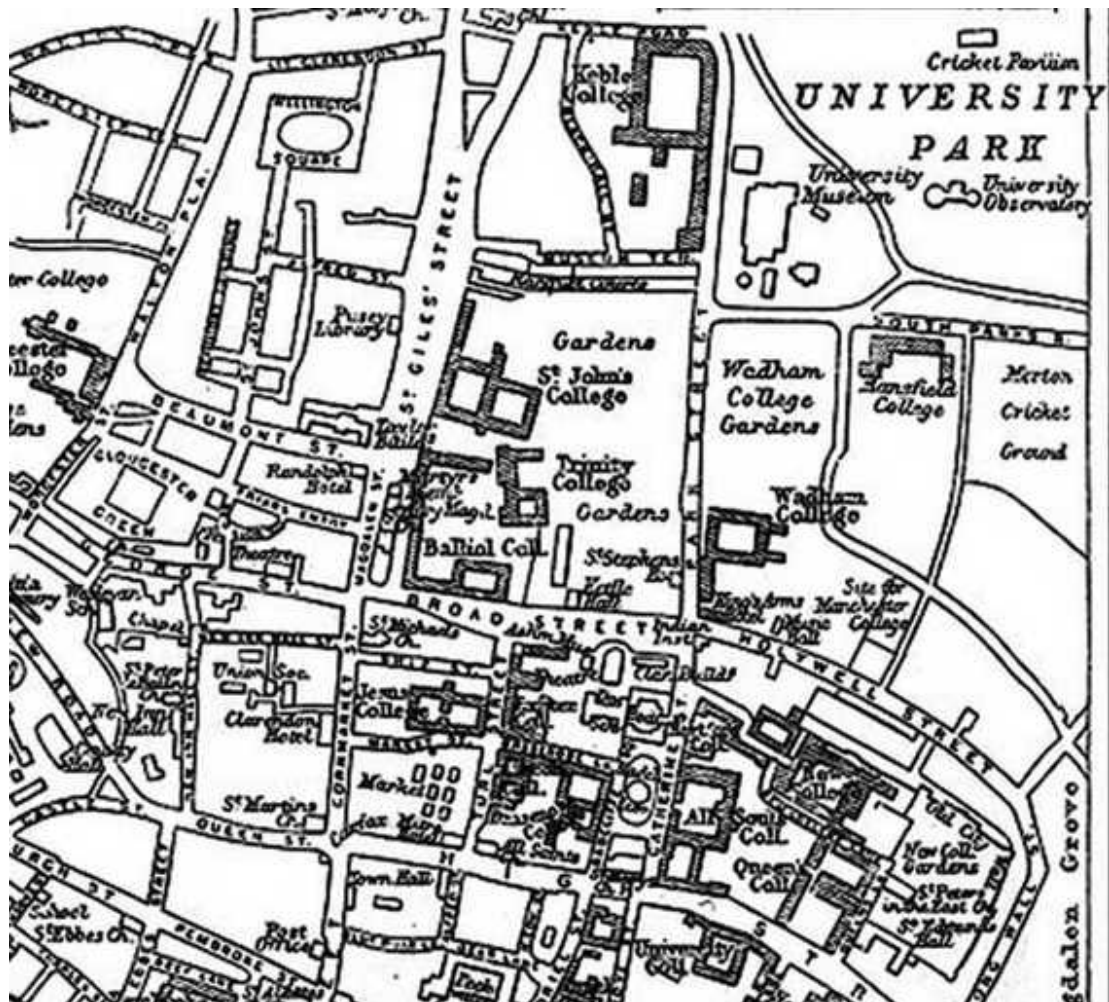


The ghost in the machine

With his idea of mind–body dualism, Descartes set the agenda for modern thinking in metaphysics. Not all philosophers agreed with him, however; some argued that everything that exists has a physical substance, others that all reality is fundamentally mental and immaterial. But in 1949, Gilbert Ryle challenged the distinction between mental and physical substances in *The Concept of Mind*. It is wrong, he said, to consider the mind as a place where thoughts, knowledge and sensations exist in the same way as our physical senses reside in the body. Ryle dismissed the notion of an immaterial mental substance separate from a physical one as ‘the ghost in the machine’, the result of a ‘category mistake’. The error Cartesian dualism makes, he said, is to consider mind and body, or mental reality and physical reality, as if they belonged to the same logical category, and then describe them as polar opposites. This category mistake is the same as considering, for example, ‘the electorate’ as some sort of ghostly entity separate from the people who vote in elections.



A classic category mistake would be a visitor to Oxford who sees its individual colleges, but then asks 'Where is the University?'